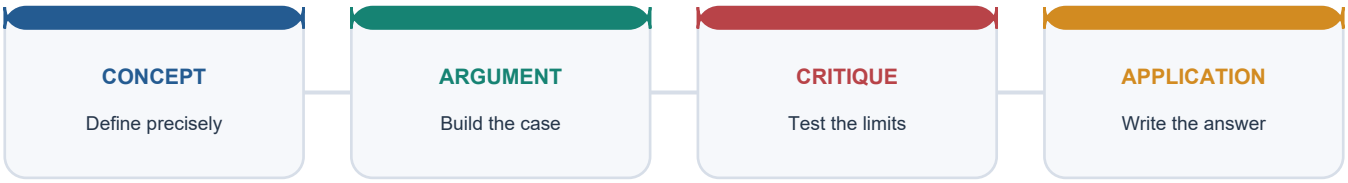
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Decline of the Mughal Empire & the Eighteenth Century - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC solved practice workbook | Foundation to advanced | MCQs, model answers and PYQ practice

LEARNING PATH



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Decline of the Mughal Empire & the Eighteenth Century - Solved Practice Workbook

Exactly thirty-two MCQs, one flat set (no sub-banks), distinct from the Learning Session's own sixteen. Correct options are deliberately rotated by actual option placement: A -> B -> C -> D repeated eight times through the full set. Every option below carries its own explanation, and every item names one specific exam trap.

UPSC traps: common misreadings vs the defensible position

TRAP CLINIC

	Correct position
'The empire collapsed immediately after 1707.'	It lingered nominally to 1857; real power fragmented gradually across the century.
'Nadir Shah conquered and ruled north India.'	He raided in 1739, looted Delhi and left -- he did not annex Mughal territory.
'Successor-state governors formally declared independence.'	They stayed nominally loyal to Delhi (khutba/sikka intact) while acting autonomously.
'Panipat III (1761) was Mughals vs Marathas.'	It was Marathas vs Ahmad Shah Abdali's coalition; the Mughal emperor was a bystander.
'Chauth was a religious tax.'	A Maratha fiscal levy (~1/4 of assessed revenue), with sardeshmukhi an additional ~10%.
'The 18th century was pure chaos with no continuity.'	Regional state formation and continuing trade/craft/culture ran alongside conflict.

Visual 34: UPSC traps -- common misreadings vs the defensible position

Visual 34: UPSC traps -- common misreadings vs the defensible position. Schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Jadunath Sarkar's historiographical strand on Mughal decline is chiefly built on:

- A. Court-chronicle and character-focused evidence emphasising Aurangzeb's personal responsibility and religious policy.

Explanation (A): Correct - Sarkar's early-twentieth-century account reads decline chiefly through Aurangzeb's own conduct and choices.

- B. Jama-hasil and jagir-transfer administrative-fiscal records.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - this is Satish Chandra's evidence base, not Sarkar's.

- C. Trade, credit and regional-court patronage records.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - this is the regional/agrarian-continuity strand associated with Alam and Subrahmanyam.

- D. UNESCO and ASI heritage-management documentation.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - heritage-policy material is a bounded modern bridge, never historiographical evidence for eighteenth-century causation.

Answer: A. Trap: Do not credit Sarkar's strand with the fiscal-administrative evidence base that actually belongs to Chandra's framework.

Q2. Bahadur Shah I's (1707-1712) policy toward Rajput rulers and Shahu's Marathas is best described as:

- A. Uniformly hostile and confrontational toward both groups.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - his approach was broadly conciliatory, not confrontational, toward Rajputs and Shahu's Marathas.

- B. Broadly conciliatory, though less successful against the Sikh rebellion under Banda Bahadur.

Explanation (B): Correct - conciliation worked with Rajputs and Shahu's camp but did not succeed against Banda Bahadur's rebellion.

- C. A direct continuation of Aurangzeb's Deccan military campaigns.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - Bahadur Shah I's reign followed Aurangzeb's death and was not itself a continuation of the Deccan wars.

- D. Entirely focused on suppressing the Sayyid Brothers.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - the Sayyid Brothers' rise to power came under Farrukhsiyar (1713-19), after Bahadur Shah I's reign.

Answer: B. Trap: Do not assume a single uniformly hostile or uniformly successful policy line across all three groups at once.

Q3. In jagirdari terminology, jama refers to:

- A. Revenue actually realised from an assignment.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - this is hasil, not jama.

- B. A noble's mansab-linked military obligation.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - jama is a fiscal-assessment term, not a military-rank term.

- C. The formally assessed revenue figure for a jagir.

Explanation (C): Correct - jama is the assessed, on-paper revenue figure, distinct from what was actually collected.

- D. Land available or awaiting assignment.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - this is paibaqi, a distinct term for assignable land.

Answer: C. Trap: Do not swap jama (assessed figure) with hasil (realised figure) - the gap between them is the crisis's measurable core.

Q4. In jagirdari terminology, hasil refers to:

- A. Land or revenue awaiting assignment.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - this is paibaqi.

- B. The formally assessed revenue figure.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - this is jama.

- C. A mansabdar's rank-linked cavalry quota.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - hasil is a fiscal-collection term, not a rank or military term.

- D. Revenue actually realised or collected from an assignment.

Explanation (D): Correct - hasil is the realised, collected figure, which frequently fell short of jama.

Answer: D. Trap: Do not treat hasil as a synonym for jama - the whole crisis depends on the two being different, measurable figures.

Q5. Be-jagiri, in this topic's account, names the condition of:

- A. A mansabdar lacking a productive jagir assignment despite holding rank.

Explanation (A): Correct - be-jagiri describes rank-holders without an adequately productive assignment, a direct symptom of the paibaqi shortage.

- B. A zamindar refusing to pay any revenue at all.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - this describes a form of resistance, not be-jagiri specifically.

- C. An emperor ruling without an active wazir.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - be-jagiri is a fiscal-assignment condition, not a description of the court's administrative structure.

- D. A jagir being permanently confiscated by the state.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - be-jagiri describes an unassigned or inadequately assigned mansabdar, not a confiscation act.

Answer: A. Trap: Do not confuse be-jagiri (a mansabdar's own condition of insufficient assignment) with a zamindar's revenue default.

Q6. The Deccan wars' fiscal legacy fed into the jagirdari crisis chiefly by:

- A. Reducing the number of nobles entitled to a jagir.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - absorption of Deccani and Maratha nobles increased, not reduced, the pool of jagir claimants.

- B. Enlarging the pool of jagir claimants while reducing the pool of undamaged, readily assignable revenue-yielding land.

Explanation (B): Correct - this dual effect (more claimants, less usable land) is the specific mechanism linking the Deccan legacy to the jagirdari crisis.

- C. Ending the mansabdari system entirely by 1707.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - the mansabdari system continued well beyond 1707; it was strained, not abolished.

- D. Creating an immediate revenue surplus for the imperial treasury.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - the Deccan wars' legacy was a fiscal strain, not a surplus.

Answer: B. Trap: Do not describe the Deccan legacy as simply reducing noble numbers - it is the mismatch between more claimants and less usable land that matters.

Q7. The 1720 noble coalition that defeated the Sayyid Brothers prominently included which noble, who later withdrew to found the Hyderabad Nizamat?

- A. Murshid Quli Khan.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - Murshid Quli Khan is Bengal's Diwan/Nawab, not part of the 1720 coalition against the Sayyids.

- B. Saadat Khan (Burhan-ul-Mulk).

Explanation (B): Incorrect - Saadat Khan became Awadh's subedar in 1722, distinct from the 1720 anti-Sayyid coalition's most prominent member.

- C. Nizam-ul-Mulk (Chin Qilich Khan).

Explanation (C): Correct - Nizam-ul-Mulk was a prominent member of the 1720 coalition and later founded the Hyderabad Nizamat.

- D. Sadashivrao Bhau.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - Sadashivrao Bhau commanded the Maratha army at Panipat in 1761, decades after the 1720 coalition.

Answer: C. Trap: Do not attribute the Hyderabad founding to whichever noble the question names first - it is specifically Nizam-ul-Mulk, verified by his later Shakar Kheda victory.

Q8. Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad's routes to autonomy are best compared as:

- A. Identical methods producing identical outcomes.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - the three states used genuinely different mechanisms, not one identical method.

- B. Three unrelated developments with no shared feature at all.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - despite different mechanisms, they share the outcome of converting real control into durable power while retaining a formal Mughal link.

- C. Purely military conquests with no fiscal dimension.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - Bengal's route was fiscal (revenue-farming), not primarily military.

- D. Three distinct mechanisms (revenue-farming, zamindar accommodation, subedar-to-sovereignty conversion) converging on a shared outcome of real autonomy with retained formal Mughal legitimacy.

Explanation (D): Correct - this is the topic's own explicit three-way comparison, naming a shared outcome despite different specific mechanisms.

Answer: D. Trap: Do not treat 'successor state' as one undifferentiated method - name each state's own specific mechanism.

Q9. Saadat Khan (Burhan-ul-Mulk), Awadh's subedar from 1722, built the province's autonomy chiefly through:

- A. Accommodation with local zamindars and taluqdars rather than confrontation.

Explanation (A): Correct - Saadat Khan negotiated revenue terms with existing zamindars, leaving local landed power intact, and this was continued by Safdarjung.

- B. A stabilised revenue-farming (ijaradari) settlement identical to Bengal's.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - this is Bengal's route under Murshid Quli Khan, a distinct mechanism from Awadh's zamindar accommodation.

- C. Military conquest of Hyderabad's Deccan territory.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - Awadh's autonomy did not rest on conquering Hyderabad.

- D. Direct alliance with Ahmad Shah Abdali against the Mughal centre.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - Awadh's Nawab Shuja-ud-Daulah later fought alongside Shah Alam II against the British at Buxar (1764), not alongside Abdali against Delhi.

Answer: A. Trap: Do not collapse Awadh's zamindar-accommodation route into Bengal's separate revenue-farming route - they are two distinct mechanisms.

Q10. Nizam-ul-Mulk secured effective Deccan autonomy after defeating a rival Mughal-appointed governor at which 1724 battle?

- A. The Third Battle of Panipat.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - Panipat III was fought in 1761 against Abdali's coalition, unrelated to Nizam-ul-Mulk's Deccan consolidation.

- B. The Battle of Shakar Kheda.

Explanation (B): Correct - Nizam-ul-Mulk defeated a rival governor at Shakar Kheda in 1724, establishing what became the Nizamat of Hyderabad.

- C. The Battle of Karnal.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - Karnal (1739) was Nadir Shah's victory over Muhammad Shah's forces, not Nizam-ul-Mulk's Deccan battle.

- D. The Battle of Buxar.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - Buxar (1764) belongs to the Company-era transition, Modern History's material.

Answer: B. Trap: Do not substitute a better-known later battle (Panipat, Karnal, Buxar) for Nizam-ul-Mulk's own specific 1724 Deccan victory.

Q11. The Jat formation around Agra-Mathura, whose base at Bharatpur became a significant eighteenth-century power, was consolidated under leaders including:

- A. Murshid Quli Khan and Saadat Khan.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - these are Bengal's and Awadh's successor-state figures, not Jat leaders.

- B. Najib-ud-Daulah and the Dal Khalsa misls.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - Najib-ud-Daulah is a Rohilla Afghan chief and the Dal Khalsa is the Sikh misls' umbrella, both distinct from the Jat formation.

- C. Churaman, Badan Singh and later Suraj Mal.

Explanation (C): Correct - these leaders consolidated the agrarian, peasant-rooted Jat zamindari base culminating in Suraj Mal's Bharatpur state.

- D. Sadashivrao Bhau and Vishwasrao.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - these are Maratha commanders at Panipat, not Jat leaders.

Answer: C. Trap: Do not substitute Rohilla, Sikh or Maratha named leaders for the Jat formation's own specific leadership line.

Q12. Rohilla Afghan chiefs, prominently including Najib-ud-Daulah, carved out a separate regional power base known as:

- A. The Nizamat of Hyderabad.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - this is Nizam-ul-Mulk's Deccan successor state, unrelated to the Rohillas.

- B. The Dal Khalsa confederacy.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - the Dal Khalsa is the Sikh misls' shared umbrella, not the Rohilla base.

- C. Bharatpur.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - Bharatpur is the Jat state's base under Suraj Mal.

- D. Rohilkhand.

Explanation (D): Correct - the Rohilla Afghan chiefs, with Najib-ud-Daulah prominent among them, established Rohilkhand as their separate power base.

Answer: D. Trap: Do not confuse Rohilkhand (the Rohilla Afghan base) with the Sikh Dal Khalsa or the Jat Bharatpur state - all three arose from the same broader collapse of central authority but are three distinct formations.

Q13. The Maratha polity's own succession contest, resolved through Shahu's ascendancy and his Peshwa Balaji Vishwanath, was a dispute between Shahu and:

- A. His aunt Tarabai's rival camp.

Explanation (A): Correct - the Shahu-Tarabai succession dispute, following Shivaji's line splitting, was resolved through Shahu's ascendancy and consolidated through Balaji Vishwanath.

- B. Nizam-ul-Mulk's Hyderabad claimants.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - Nizam-ul-Mulk is a Mughal noble turned Hyderabad's founder, unrelated to the internal Maratha succession dispute.

- C. The Sayyid Brothers.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - the Sayyid Brothers controlled the Mughal wizarat at Delhi, a separate contest from the Maratha polity's own internal succession.

- D. Ahmad Shah Abdali.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - Abdali is the Afghan invader who fought the Marathas decades later at Panipat, not a party to their internal succession dispute.

Answer: A. Trap: Do not confuse the Maratha polity's own internal Shahu-Tarabai succession dispute with the separate Mughal-centre succession disputes examined earlier in this topic.

Q14. By well-established tradition, the treasure Nadir Shah carried back to Persia after his 1739 raid is said to have included:

- A. The Kohinoor diamond alone, with no other named item.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - tradition names both the Peacock Throne and the Koh-i-Noor together, not the diamond alone.

- B. The Peacock Throne and the Koh-i-Noor diamond.

Explanation (B): Correct - both items are named together by well-established tradition as part of Nadir Shah's plunder.

- C. The original Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque inscriptions.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - this is unrelated Sultanate-era material, not part of Nadir Shah's 1739 plunder.

- D. Shah Jahan's original manuscript library only.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - the traditionally cited items are the Peacock Throne and Koh-i-Noor, not a manuscript library.

Answer: B. Trap: Do not name only one of the two traditionally cited items - the Peacock Throne and the Koh-i-Noor are cited together.

Q15. Ahmad Shah Abdali's invasions across 1748-1767 are best described as a contest for the Punjab frontier involving:

- A. Only the Mughal centre and Abdali, with no other claimant.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - at least three regional claimants contested the vacuum, not just two parties.

- B. Only the Marathas and the Sikh misls, with the Mughal centre absent entirely.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - Mughal remnants, Sikh power and the Marathas were all simultaneously contesting the frontier alongside Abdali.

- C. Mughal governors' remnants, rising Sikh power, and eventually the Marathas, all contesting the vacuum simultaneously.

Explanation (C): Correct - this three-way (at least) simultaneous contest is the specific point this topic makes about the frontier's collapse.

- D. A single unified Indian coalition against Abdali throughout the period.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - the various regional claimants did not act as one unified coalition across the whole 1748-1767 span.

Answer: C. Trap: Do not reduce Abdali's invasions to a simple two-sided Mughal-versus-Abdali contest - name the multiple simultaneous regional claimants.

Q16. At the Third Battle of Panipat (1761), the Maratha commander Sadashivrao Bhau was accompanied by which figure who was killed in the battle?

- A. Nizam-ul-Mulk.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - Nizam-ul-Mulk died decades earlier and was not present at Panipat.

- B. Najib-ud-Daulah.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - Najib-ud-Daulah was a Rohilla chief fighting on Abdali's side, not the Peshwa's heir killed alongside Bhau.

- C. Murshid Quli Khan.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - Murshid Quli Khan is Bengal's Nawab, unconnected to the Panipat campaign.

- D. Vishwasrao, the Peshwa's young heir.

Explanation (D): Correct - Vishwasrao accompanied Sadashivrao Bhau and was killed in the battle, among many other heavy Maratha casualties.

Answer: D. Trap: Do not name a Mughal-court or Rohilla figure as the Peshwa's heir killed at Panipat - it is specifically Vishwasrao.

Q17. Maratha power after the 1761 defeat at Panipat is best described as:

- A. Substantially restored within about a decade under Peshwa Madhavrao I, in the Deccan/Malwa/central India rather than a Punjab return.

Explanation (A): Correct - this is the topic's own qualified account of recovery, specifying both the timeframe and the region of restored strength.

- B. Permanently and completely destroyed with no recovery.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - the topic explicitly frames Panipat as a check, not a terminal collapse, and records recovery under Madhavrao I.

- C. Immediately restored to full strength within the same year, including in the Punjab.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - recovery took about a decade, and it occurred in the Deccan/Malwa/central India, not as a Punjab return.

- D. Transferred entirely to British control immediately after the battle.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - no automatic transfer of Maratha power to British control followed directly from Panipat.

Answer: A. Trap: Do not claim either total destruction or an instant same-year recovery - the topic specifies a roughly decade-long recovery in a different region (not Punjab).

Q18. The regional/agrarian-focused historiography (named in the source material as Alam and Subrahmanyam) is used in this topic chiefly to caution against:

- A. Overstating the Sayyid Brothers' administrative competence.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - this caution concerns reading eighteenth-century decline as uniform economic-cultural collapse, not the Sayyids' competence specifically.

- B. Reading eighteenth-century "decline" as a uniform, empire-wide economic and cultural collapse.

Explanation (B): Correct - this is precisely the caution this named historiographical strand supplies to the central fragmentation-versus-continuity thesis.

- C. Understating Aurangzeb's role in the Deccan wars.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - this concerns economic-cultural continuity, not Aurangzeb's Deccan role specifically.

- D. Accepting Satish Chandra's fiscal framework at all.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - the regional/agrarian strand supplements rather than rejects Chandra's framework; they are read alongside each other.

Answer: B. Trap: Do not attach this specific historiographical caution to the wrong target - it concerns uniform economic-cultural collapse, not any single ruler's competence.

Q19. Bengal's Jagat Seth banking and credit house is cited in this topic as evidence for:

- A. The complete absence of any credit institution in the eighteenth century.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - Jagat Seth is cited as a surviving, active institution, not evidence of absence.

- B. A purely political, non-economic form of continuity.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - Jagat Seth is specifically economic (banking/credit) evidence, not a political example.

- C. Continuing economic activity (banking and credit) across the eighteenth century despite political fragmentation.

Explanation (C): Correct - Jagat Seth is the most frequently cited named example of continuing economic institutions financing both regional-court and trading-company activity.

- D. The Maratha confederacy's own internal fiscal structure.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - Jagat Seth is a Bengal-based banking house, not part of the Maratha confederacy's structure.

Answer: C. Trap: Do not cite Jagat Seth as evidence of absence or political continuity - it is specifically named economic (banking/credit) continuity evidence.

Q20. The relationship between agrarian cultivation and eighteenth-century trade-route disruption, in this topic's account, is best described as:

- A. Total disruption of both cultivation and trade routes everywhere at once.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - cultivation mostly continued; disruption was specific to certain trade routes, not universal.

- B. Total continuity of both cultivation and trade routes, with no disruption anywhere.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - specific trade routes did suffer real, localised disruption during active campaign seasons.

- C. Cultivation collapsing while trade routes remained entirely undisturbed.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - this reverses the actual pattern; it is cultivation that mostly continued.

- D. Cultivation mostly continuing while specific trade routes suffered real, localised disruption during active campaign seasons such as Abdali's Punjab corridor and the Panipat marches.

Explanation (D): Correct - continuity and disruption coexisted rather than one uniformly displacing the other, which is the topic's precise nuance on this point.

Answer: D. Trap: Do not flatten this into either total continuity or total collapse - the topic's own nuance is that cultivation and route disruption coexisted unevenly.

Q21. Cultural patronage in the eighteenth century, as central Mughal patronage contracted, is described in this topic as chiefly sustained by:

- A. Regional successor courts, including Awadh's Lucknow establishment and Hyderabad's Deccani court.

Explanation (A): Correct - these regional courts took up literary, architectural and artistic patronage as the political centre's own patronage contracted.

- B. The British East India Company's own cultural institutions.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - Company cultural patronage belongs to Modern History, not this topic's eighteenth-century continuity evidence.

- C. No institution at all - patronage simply ceased.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - the topic's point is precisely that patronage continued via regional courts, not that it ceased.

- D. The Sayyid Brothers' wizarat administration.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - the Sayyid wizarat (1713-1720) predates the broader eighteenth-century patronage shift to regional successor courts.

Answer: A. Trap: Do not credit the Sayyid wizarat or an outside institution for a continuity that this topic specifically attributes to regional successor courts.

Q22. Before 1757, the English East India Company's political and military footprint in the subcontinent is best described in this topic as:

- A. Already extending inland across most of northern India as the dominant political power.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - inland political dominance came only after Plassey (1757) and the Company's subsequent territorial expansion, not before it.

- B. Already fighting the inland Carnatic Wars (from the 1740s) alongside regional claimants, but not yet a dominant inland political power or a formal territorial ruler.

Explanation (B): Correct - before 1757 the Company was already militarily engaged inland through the Carnatic Wars, but formal Company territorial rule (from the Bengal Diwani of 1765 onward) still lay ahead; its presence was real and partly inland, but not yet dominant political paramountcy.

- C. Non-existent, since the Company had no presence in India before 1757.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - the Company had traded from coastal settlements since the seventeenth century and had already fought the inland Carnatic Wars from the 1740s; its presence was real, not absent.

- D. Exercised through direct annexation of the Mughal court at Delhi.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - no such annexation occurred before 1757; the Mughal court at Delhi remained under indigenous/regional control.

Answer: B. Trap: Do not conflate the Company's later inland political paramountcy (post-1757 annexation and Diwani) with its earlier, already-inland-fighting but not-yet-dominant Carnatic Wars-era presence; equally, do not claim it was coastal-only, which ignores the Carnatic Wars.

Q23. Reading Mughal decline as a story that reads history backward from the known outcome of British rule is an example of which wrong framing this topic explicitly names and rejects?

- A. The religious-monocausal framing.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - this is a separate wrong framing (blaming religious policy alone), not the backward-reading error.

- B. The centre-region spectrum framing.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - the centre-region spectrum is this topic's own valid analytical tool, not a wrong framing to reject.

- C. Teleology.

Explanation (C): Correct - teleology names precisely this error of reading history backward from a known outcome, which this topic explicitly rejects.

- D. The convergence-causation framing.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - convergence-causation is this topic's own preferred, valid framing, not a wrong one.

Answer: C. Trap: Do not confuse this topic's own valid analytical frames (centre-region spectrum, convergence-causation) with the wrong framings it explicitly names and rejects (teleology, religious monocausality).

Q24. Ignoring the fiscal-administrative, political and external-shock evidence examined across this topic in favour of a single-cause explanation centred only on religious policy is an example of which wrong framing?

- A. The centre-region spectrum.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - this is a valid analytical tool used in this topic, not a wrong framing.

- B. Teleology.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - teleology is the separate error of reading history backward from a known outcome.

- C. The layered-fiscal-sovereignty framing.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - this describes Maratha chauth/sardeshmukhi claims, an accurate description, not a wrong framing.

- D. The religious-monocausal framing.

Explanation (D): Correct - reducing decline to religious policy alone, while ignoring the fiscal-administrative, political and external-shock evidence, is exactly the religious-monocausal error this topic explicitly rejects.

Answer: D. Trap: Do not mistake this topic's own valid descriptive frames for the specific wrong framing being tested - the religious-monocausal error is about ignoring multiple evidenced strands in favour of one.

Q25. Alivardi Khan's containment of the Maratha bargi raids into Bengal during the 1740s is best read in this topic as evidence that:

- A. Regional successor states could sustain meaningful state capacity and negotiated/military resilience even under external pressure, not simply collapse passively.

Explanation (A): Correct - Alivardi Khan's mixed negotiated-payment/military response shows a successor state retaining real administrative-military capacity, consistent with this topic's continuity thesis.

- B. Bengal had already been annexed by the Marathas by the 1740s.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - the bargi raids were incursions and tribute pressure, not a territorial annexation of Bengal.

- C. The Mughal centre in Delhi directly organised Bengal's defence against the raids.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - Bengal's autonomous Nawabi, not the Mughal centre, organised its own response.

- D. The raids were entirely repelled through British East India Company intervention.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - the Company's major Bengal political role began later, after 1757, not through repelling the 1740s bargi raids.

Answer: A. Trap: Do not read the bargi raids as either a Maratha annexation of Bengal or as evidence of Company/Mughal-centre intervention - Bengal's own Nawabi handled it.

Q26. At the Third Battle of Panipat (1761), Awadh's Nawab Shuja-ud-Daulah is recorded in this topic as:

- A. Fighting on the Maratha side against Ahmad Shah Abdali's coalition.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - Shuja-ud-Daulah fought alongside Abdali's coalition, not the Maratha side.

- B. Fighting alongside Ahmad Shah Abdali's coalition, extending Awadh's frontier role beyond fiscal-administrative autonomy.

Explanation (B): Correct - his participation alongside Abdali's coalition extended Awadh's regional role from fiscal-administrative autonomy into frontier military alignment.

- C. Remaining entirely neutral and uninvolved in the battle.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - Awadh was not neutral; Shuja-ud-Daulah actively fought in the coalition.

- D. Leading the Maratha army in place of Sadashivrao Bhau.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - Sadashivrao Bhau led the Maratha side; Shuja-ud-Daulah fought against, not in place of, him.

Answer: B. Trap: Do not confuse Awadh's earlier fiscal-administrative autonomy (Saadat Khan/Safdarjung) with its later, distinct frontier-military role under Shuja-ud-Daulah at Panipat.

Q27. Bahadur Shah I's reign (1707-1712) is followed in the court succession spine by which emperor (1712-1713), dominated by his patron Zulfiqar Khan?

- A. Farrukhsiyar.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - Farrukhsiyar (1713-1719) followed Jahandar Shah, not Bahadur Shah I directly.

- B. Muhammad Shah.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - Muhammad Shah's reign began in 1719, several emperors later.

- C. Jahandar Shah.

Explanation (C): Correct - Jahandar Shah (1712-13), dominated by his noble patron Zulfiqar Khan, directly followed Bahadur Shah I and was overthrown by Farrukhsiyar in 1713.

- D. Shah Alam II.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - Shah Alam II's reign began only in 1759, decades after Bahadur Shah I.

Answer: C. Trap: Do not skip ahead to a later emperor - the court succession spine's immediate next name after Bahadur Shah I is specifically Jahandar Shah.

Q28. During Muhammad Shah's long reign (1719-1748), which development involving Nizam-ul-Mulk occurred?

- A. He was executed by the Sayyid Brothers.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - Nizam-ul-Mulk was part of the coalition that defeated the Sayyid Brothers, not their victim.

- B. He negotiated the 1719 chauth-sardeshmukhi settlement with the Marathas.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - that settlement is associated with the Sayyid Brothers' administration, not specifically Nizam-ul-Mulk.

- C. He was killed at the Battle of Karnal in 1739.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - Nizam-ul-Mulk survived Karnal; it was Muhammad Shah's forces that were defeated there by Nadir Shah, not a battle that killed the Nizam.

- D. He effectively withdrew to the Deccan and founded what became the independent Nizamat of Hyderabad.

Explanation (D): Correct - this withdrawal and the 1724 Shakar Kheda victory occurred during Muhammad Shah's reign, alongside continuing factional competition at court and Nadir Shah's 1739 raid.

Answer: D. Trap: Do not attach unrelated events (the Sayyids' execution, the 1719 Maratha settlement, death at Karnal) to Nizam-ul-Mulk - his own specific development is the Deccan withdrawal and Hyderabad's founding.

Q29. Farrukhsiyar's 1719 deposition and killing by the Sayyid Brothers is cited in this topic as the clearest evidence that:

- A. The Mughal throne had become a prize contested by noble coalitions, not merely a hereditary office weakly filled.

Explanation (A): Correct - this is exactly the significance this topic attaches to Farrukhsiyar's fate at the Sayyids' hands.

- B. Mughal succession had returned to strict primogeniture by 1719.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - the episode shows the opposite: kingmaking by noble coalitions, not orderly primogeniture.

- C. The Marathas had by this point annexed Delhi outright.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - the Marathas gained a fiscal settlement (chauth/sardeshmukhi) around this time, not territorial annexation of Delhi.

- D. Nadir Shah had already invaded by this date.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - Nadir Shah's invasion came twenty years later, in 1739.

Answer: A. Trap: Do not read Farrukhsiyar's fate as evidence of restored orderly succession - it demonstrates the opposite, that the throne was a contested prize.

Q30. The Sayyid-dominated administration's 1713 abolition of jizyah occurred alongside which other significant development named in this topic?

- A. The Third Battle of Panipat.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - Panipat III occurred in 1761, decades after the 1713 jizyah abolition.

- B. A settlement recognising Maratha chauth and sardeshmukhi claims over the Deccan subahs.

Explanation (B): Correct - both the jizyah abolition (1713) and the Maratha fiscal settlement (formalised in 1719 under continuing Sayyid dominance) are cited together as evidence the Sayyid period was not uniformly destructive.

- C. Nadir Shah's sack of Delhi.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - Nadir Shah's raid came in 1739, well after the Sayyid period ended in 1720.

- D. The founding of the Hyderabad Nizamat.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - Hyderabad's founding followed Nizam-ul-Mulk's 1724 Shakar Kheda victory, after the Sayyid wizarat had already fallen in 1720.

Answer: B. Trap: Do not pair the 1713 jizyah abolition with a later, unrelated event - the topic pairs it specifically with the Maratha chauth-sardeshmukhi settlement to show the Sayyid period's mixed record.

Q31. The centre-region spectrum's key point about Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad is that all three, despite real autonomy, continued for varying periods to:

- A. Reject any nominal link to the Mughal centre.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - this is precisely what the three states did not do; they retained a nominal link.

- B. Pay full assessed jama revenue directly to Delhi without any local retention.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - the point is about seeking formal confirmation of authority, not about revenue-remittance practice.

- C. Seek formal Mughal confirmation of their governors' authority.

Explanation (C): Correct - this is the specific continuing link the centre-region spectrum highlights even as real power devolved to the regions.

- D. Submit their armies to direct Mughal command.

Explanation (D): Incorrect - the states each built and controlled their own military forces; only nominal legitimacy, not military command, remained linked to Delhi.

Answer: C. Trap: Do not claim the three states rejected all formal Mughal linkage - the spectrum's whole point is that nominal confirmation-seeking persisted alongside devolved real power.

Q32. This topic's convergence-causation framing explicitly rejects reducing Mughal decline to:

- A. A single administrative-fiscal mechanism.

Explanation (A): Incorrect - the fiscal-administrative (jagirdari) strand is one legitimate contributing input in the convergence, not the framing's rejected target.

- B. A combination of succession, fiscal and external-shock factors.

Explanation (B): Incorrect - this combination is exactly what the convergence framing affirms, not rejects.

- C. Regional-power fragmentation as a contributing factor.

Explanation (C): Incorrect - regional fragmentation is affirmed as a genuine strand in the convergence, not rejected.

- D. Aurangzeb's personal religious policy alone.

Explanation (D): Correct - the source book explicitly frames decline as a convergence of causes and explicitly rejects reducing it to Aurangzeb's personal religious policy alone.

Answer: D. Trap: Do not mistake one of the convergence framing's affirmed contributing strands for the single-cause explanation it explicitly rejects.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PART X - SOURCES, PYQ AUDIT AND PRACTICE

Transparent PYQ audit and route decision

Audit scope: every Prelims and Mains GS-I/GS-II/Essay routing ledger and integration audit currently in the repository covering 2018 through 2026 was checked line by line for any question mentioning the post-1707 succession, the Sayyid wizarat, the jagirdari crisis, jama/hasil/paibaqi/be-jagiri, Bengal/Awadh/Hyderabad, Jats/Sikhs/Marathas in their eighteenth-century political form, Nadir Shah, Abdali, or the Third Battle of Panipat.

Audit result: `PYQ-INTEGRATION-AUDIT-2018-2023.md`, `PYQ-INTEGRATION-AUDIT-2024-2025.md` and `PYQ-INTEGRATION-AUDIT-2026.md` each explicitly list Medieval Topic 25 basic and advanced files as owning no routed question across their respective windows. No Prelims or Mains question in any checked ledger is routed to Topic 25.

2026 provenance, stated separately: `_PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2026.md` (the official 2026 Set-A scan's own routing record) lists zero Medieval-Indian-History rows of any kind, so Topic 25 owns no 2026 Prelims Set-A question. The governing 2026 Mains ledger `_PYQ-GS1-2026.md` lists no Topic-25-routed 2026 Mains GS-I item; its own Q11 ("Vijayanagara architecture exemplifies the amalgamation of past traditions with contemporary practices") is explicitly routed to Indian Art & Culture Topic 03 (Temple Architecture and Chandella-Khajuraho), not to Topic 25. So Topic 25 owns no 2026 Mains GS-I question either. These two absences are independent findings from separate ledger types, and both ledgers agree with each other.

No other medieval Mains item is borrowed: the only Vijayanagara-adjacent Mains item anywhere near this audit's scope is the 2026 ledger's Q11, on Vijayanagara **architecture** (not Vijayanagara-Bahmani political/administrative history) - it is routed by `_PYQ-GS1-2026.md` to **Indian Art & Culture Topic 03**, not to Medieval History Topic 09 and not to Topic 25, so it falls outside this topic's 1707-1761 window and is not used as a bridge illustration here. The single Mains item this package does use as a bridge (Mains 1, below) is the verified 2022 Mains GS-I Company-armies question, owned by Modern History Topic 05, not by any medieval topic.

Workbook/session policy consequence: because this topic owns zero verified PYQs, this package does not fabricate a "Topic 25 PYQ list." Instead, three thematically adjacent items - each verified for exact wording against reliable sources, and each explicitly routed elsewhere by this repository's own ledgers - are presented below strictly as bounded bridge illustrations. Only one of the three (the 2022 Mains GS-I Company-armies item) receives solved treatment in this workbook; the other two are named only as one-line boundary reminders and are not worked as solved questions here.

Adjacent evidence is not substitution: an adjacent PYQ illustrates a related concept; it is never claimed as "this topic's own question," and a candidate should not cite it in an answer as if Topic 25 were its subject. The three items are:

1. **2021 Prelims** (local ledger numbering) - ascending-size sequence of Paragana-Sarkar-Suba - routed to **Medieval Topic 16** (State and Government under Akbar). Used here only as a one-line boundary reminder that provincial-administrative-hierarchy questions belong to Topic 16, not Topic 25.
2. **2021 Prelims** (local ledger numbering; the same question is indexed elsewhere under a different set/booklet numbering, confirmed identical by content match) - statements on the Nizamat of Arcot, the Mysore Kingdom and Rohilkhand - routed to **Modern History Topic 02** (Indian States and Society, 18th Century). Used here as the best available bounded-bridge illustration, since its subject matter (successor/regional states) is precisely what Topic 25 teaches, even though the routing ledger places the question itself under Modern History's forward-looking treatment.
3. **2022 Mains GS-I**, 10 marks/150 words - why Company armies staffed mainly by Indian soldiers consistently defeated larger, better-equipped Indian armies - routed to **Modern History Topic 05** (British Territorial Expansion). Used here only as a forward "bridge" illustration for the non-inevitability theme (subtopic 23), not as this topic's own Mains question.

No further PYQ is claimed for this topic. Where this package's own original MCQs and Mains questions appear below, they are clearly original practice material, not represented as previous UPSC questions.

Examiner-grade solved Mains practice (1 verified adjacent PYQ + 6 original answers)



Visual 31: answer spine -- 10-mark: structural decline in four moves

Visual 31: answer spine -- 10-mark: structural decline in four moves. Schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Mains 1 - 10 marks | 150 words

ADJACENT VERIFIED PYQ - not owned by Topic 25: this is the repository's routing ledgers' own record of 2022 Mains GS-I Q2, owned by Modern History Topic 05 (British Territorial Expansion). It is reproduced here, with exact verified wording, only as a bounded forward-bridge illustration for this topic's non-inevitability theme; the solved answer below is original practice by this package, not an official UPSC model answer.

Question: Why did the armies of the British East India Company - mostly comprising of Indian soldiers - win consistently against the more numerous and better equipped armies of the then Indian rulers? Give reasons.

Directive alignment: Give reasons for a consistent pattern, without retelling any single battle narrative.

Introduction: By the mid-to-late eighteenth century, Company armies staffed mainly by Indian sepoys repeatedly defeated larger Indian successor-state forces - a pattern this topic can only explain via its preconditions, not the mechanism itself.

Claim - evidence - analysis: First, Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad and the Marathas were regionally strong but rivalrous, not united - the Nadir Shah, Abdali and Panipat contests show Indian powers already fighting each other before the Company rose. Second, these rivalries let the Company ally with one power against another, an opportunity this topic's own fragmentation had created.

Qualification: The Company's disciplined infantry, artillery and revenue-funded army - the actual mechanism - belongs to Topic 05, not here.

Verdict: This topic supplies precondition, not mechanism: fragmentation created the rivalrous landscape the Company exploited; the winning method is Topic 05's material.

Why this earns marks: It answers the "give reasons" directive from this topic's own bounded vantage, cites the precondition it can defensibly supply, and explicitly hands off the mechanism to its correct owner rather than overreaching.

Demand decoding: This is a "give reasons" causal-explanation demand: it requires a mechanism-level answer to why the winning pattern is consistent across successor states, explicitly bounded to what this topic can supply versus what belongs to Topic 05.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: This answer functions as a precondition-level supplement to Modern History Topic 05's own military-fiscal explanation; use it only to establish the pre-1757 regional landscape, never as a substitute for Topic 05's actual winning mechanism.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 150 words: one line naming the pattern, two sentences of named evidence on rivalrous successor states and the Company's alliance-exploitation, one explicit hand-off line to Topic 05's mechanism, and a closing one-line verdict.

How to improve this answer: Name one additional specific Company alliance against a named successor state to sharpen the "opportunity structure" claim beyond a general statement of rivalry.

Mains 2 - 10 marks | 150 words

Question: Explain the jama-hasil gap and its structural role in the eighteenth-century jagirdari crisis.

Directive alignment: Explain a mechanism precisely, using defined terms, not a general narrative of "decline."

Introduction: The jagirdari crisis is best explained as a measurable fiscal mismatch, not a story about individual noble failings.

Claim - evidence - analysis: Jama, the assessed revenue figure, frequently ran ahead of hasil, the revenue actually realised, because of local resistance, poor harvests, or an assignee's weak control. This gap widened as the Deccan campaigns swelled the mansabdari ranks while damaging the lands that might otherwise have supplied fresh paibaqi (reserve, assignable land). Facing be-jagiri, mansabdars extracted aggressively from short-tenure jagirs, discouraging investment and provoking zamindar resistance that further widened the gap - a self-reinforcing loop, not a one-off shortfall.

Qualification: This is a structural-administrative account; present it alongside, not as a replacement for, the political (noble factionalism) and external-shock (Nadir Shah, Abdali) strands feeding the same crisis.

Verdict: The jama-hasil gap is the crisis's measurable core, and the feedback loop is what made it self-sustaining rather than self-correcting.

Why this earns marks: It defines every technical term before using it, states the feedback mechanism explicitly, and avoids collapsing a structural argument into a moral one.

Demand decoding: This definitional "explain" demand requires jama, hasil, be-jagiri and paibaqi to be used as distinct technical terms feeding one mechanism, not folded into a general narrative of "fiscal decline."

Detailed examiner-grade model status: This answer's jama-hasil mechanism is this topic's own core material and may be used directly, without any cross-topic hand-off, since jagirdari mechanics are wholly owned here.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 150 words: define jama and hasil in one line each, state the widening-gap mechanism in two sentences, and close with the be-jagiri feedback-loop verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add one named illustrative instance of a jagir subjected to be-jagiri-driven aggressive extraction to move the answer from definition toward applied evidence.

Mains 3 - 10 marks | 150 words

Question: In what ways was Nadir Shah's 1739 invasion an accelerant of Mughal decline rather than its origin?

Directive alignment: Distinguish "accelerant" from "origin" explicitly, rather than treating 1739 as decline's starting point.

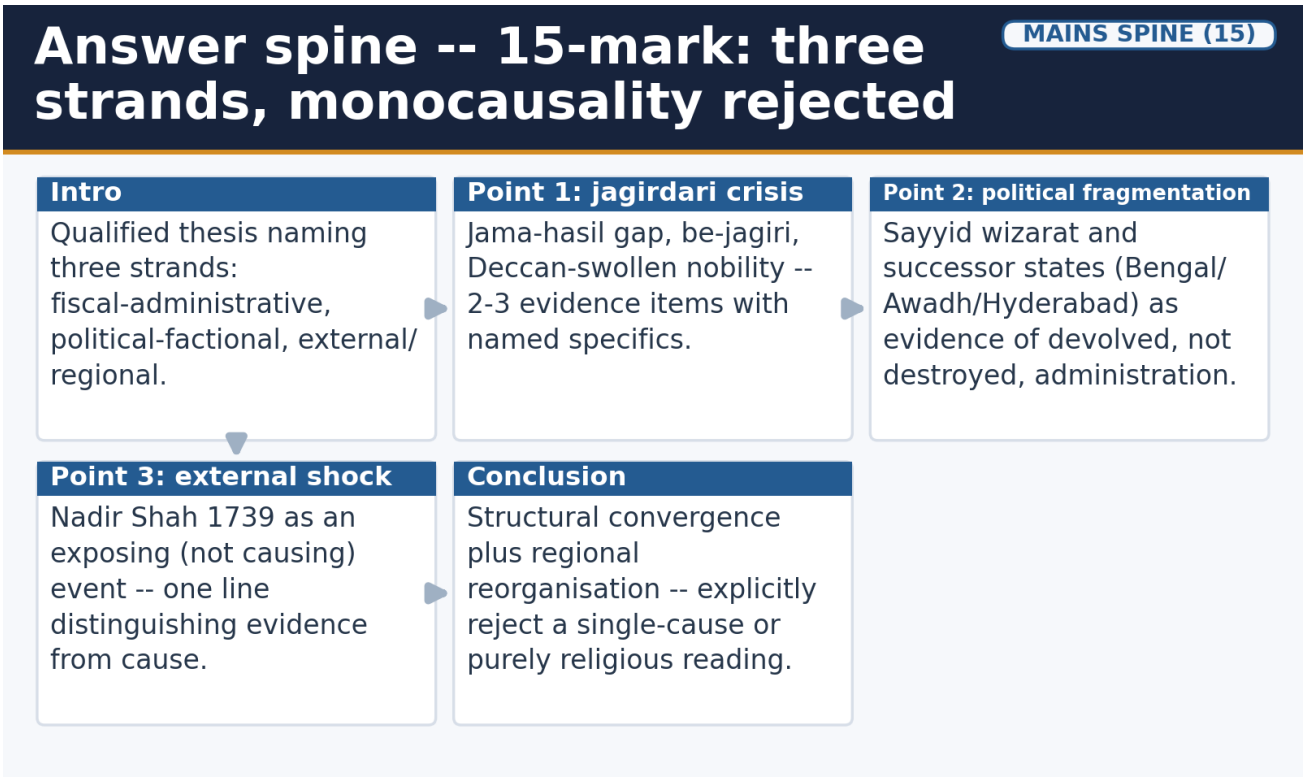
Introduction: By 1739 the jagirdari crisis and noble factionalism were already well advanced; Nadir Shah's raid intensified rather than initiated this weakness.

Claim - evidence - analysis: Nadir Shah's defeat of a substantially larger Mughal force at Karnal (exact comparative figures are not independently verifiable here) exposed a military hollowness built over three decades of post-1707 factional competition, not a sudden new failure. His plunder of Delhi's treasury and the indemnity extracted deepened the existing be-jagiri crisis by cutting resources available for jagir assignment, intensifying the same feedback loop.

Qualification: Calling the raid decline's "cause" would wrongly compress thirty prior years of structural erosion into one 1739 event; it is a stress test that revealed and worsened an existing condition.

Verdict: Nadir Shah's invasion accelerated and exposed a crisis already in motion; it was a severe shock to an already-weakened system, not the system's origin.

Why this earns marks: It uses the Karnal evidence precisely, names the specific fiscal mechanism by which the raid worsened an existing crisis, and avoids the trap of treating 1739 as decline's starting point.



Visual 32: answer spine -- 15-mark: three strands, monocausality rejected

Visual 32: answer spine -- 15-mark: three strands, monocausality rejected. Schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Demand decoding: This "in what ways" demand requires the accelerant-versus-origin distinction to be argued explicitly, using the Karnal evidence to show exposure of a pre-existing weakness rather than a fresh cause.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: This answer's Karnal evidence and fiscal-shock mechanism are this topic's own material and may be used directly.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 150 words: one sentence placing decline before 1739, two sentences on the Karnal exposure and treasury/indemnity shock, and a closing sentence naming the be-jagiri feedback link.

How to improve this answer: Name the specific pattern of post-1707 factional competition more precisely to sharpen the "already in motion" claim.

Mains 4 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Discuss the mechanisms through which Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad each achieved substantial autonomy from Mughal central authority in the eighteenth century.

Directive alignment: Discuss requires naming each state's distinct mechanism, not asserting "all three became independent" without specifying how.

Introduction: Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad each evolved from a Mughal provincial governorship into a substantially autonomous successor state, but through three genuinely different mechanisms.

Bengal's mechanism: Murshid Quli Khan's revenue-farming (ijaradari) settlement replaced disruptive jagir turnover with a more stable fiscal arrangement, and his successors, including Alivardi Khan, sustained this administration while containing external pressure such as the 1740s Maratha bargi raids.

Awadh's mechanism: Saadat Khan (Burhan-ul-Mulk) built autonomy through negotiated accommodation with existing zamindars and taluqdars rather than a fiscal overhaul, a base his successors, including Shuja-ud-Daulah, used while also taking on an exposed frontier military role.

Hyderabad's mechanism: Nizam-ul-Mulk (Asaf Jah), a senior central noble and former wazir, converted personal military strength into Deccan autonomy after his 1724 victory at Shakar Kheda, while continuing to hold Mughal-derived titles.

Qualification: All three retained formal deference to Delhi - seeking confirmation of title and maintaining ceremonial recognition - for a considerable period even while exercising real autonomy, which is why "successor state" is the accurate term rather than "rebel" or "breakaway" state.

Verdict: A shared outcome (durable regional autonomy with continued formal Mughal legitimacy) was reached by three distinct routes - revenue-farming, zamindar-accommodation, and personal-military conversion - and a strong answer must name all three mechanisms, not merely the shared outcome.

Why this earns marks: It names each state's specific mechanism with a founding figure and a dated or specific event, and closes with the shared-outcome-versus-distinct-mechanism distinction this topic's comparative method requires.

Demand decoding: This "discuss" demand requires three separately named mechanisms - Bengal's revenue-farming, Awadh's zamindar accommodation, Hyderabad's personal-military conversion - not a single shared "they became autonomous" claim.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: This answer's three mechanism-paragraphs are this topic's own comparative-method material and may be used directly, one paragraph per successor state.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 250 words: one thesis sentence, three named-mechanism paragraphs (Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad) each with a founding figure and a dated event, and a closing shared-outcome-versus-distinct-mechanism verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add Shuja-ud-Daulah's later frontier military role as a second-generation example to extend the Awadh paragraph beyond its founding mechanism.

Mains 5 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: "Eighteenth-century India witnessed political fragmentation but not economic or cultural collapse." Examine this statement with reference to specific evidence.

Directive alignment: Examine a two-part claim, providing distinct evidence for both its fragmentation half and its continuity half.

Introduction: This topic's central thesis holds that political fragmentation and considerable economic-cultural continuity ran side by side in the eighteenth century, rather than the first causing a uniform collapse of the second.

Evidence for political fragmentation: The post-1707 succession crisis, the Sayyid wizarat's kingmaking, the jagirdari feedback loop, and the rise of Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad, and Jat, Sikh and Maratha power together document real and substantial devolution of central political authority.

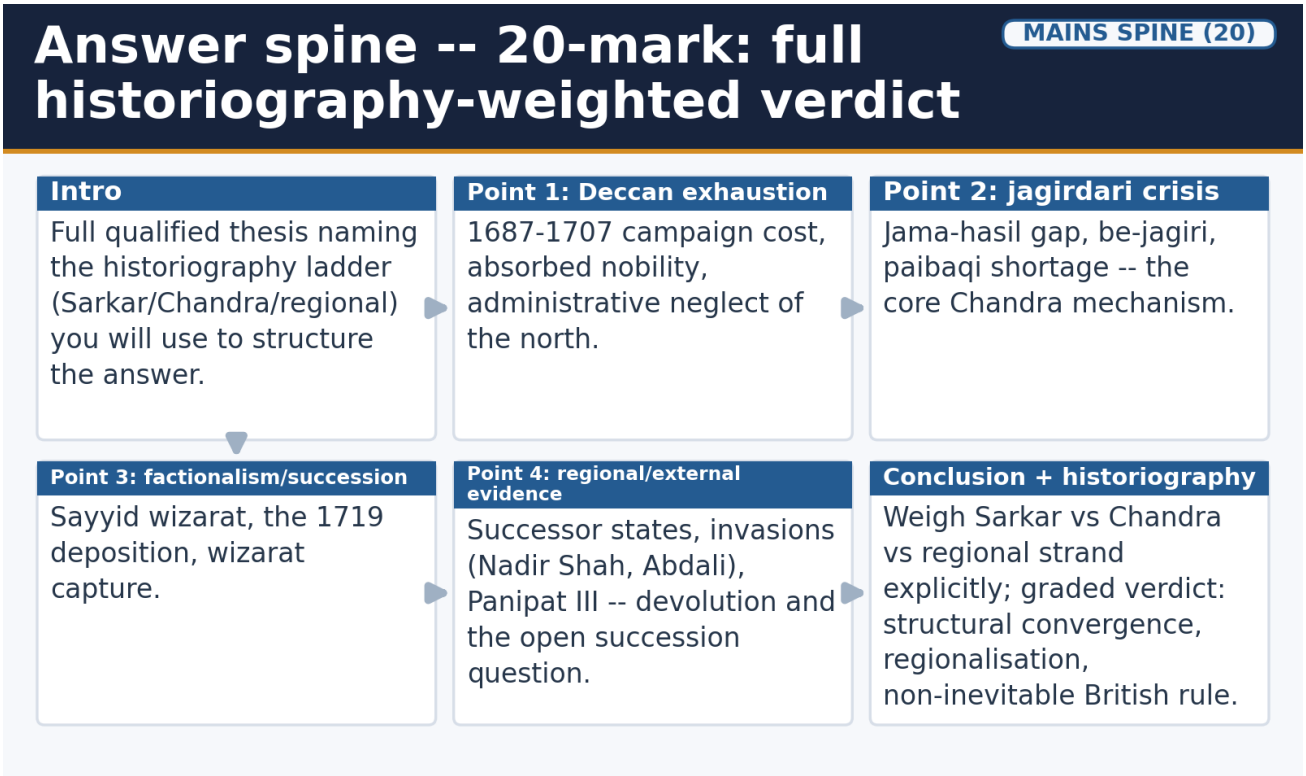
Evidence for economic continuity: Banking and credit houses, of which Bengal's Jagat Seth firm is the most cited example, continued and in some respects expanded their operations through this same period; trade networks and craft production persisted under regional-court patronage rather than uniformly collapsing.

Evidence for cultural continuity: Regional courts, particularly Awadh's Lucknow establishment and Hyderabad's Deccani court, took up literary, architectural and artistic patronage as central Mughal patronage contracted, sustaining rather than abandoning cultural production.

Qualification: This is a claim about decoupled trajectories, not a claim that nothing was lost or that regional courts perfectly replaced the imperial centre's economic and cultural role unchanged.

Verdict: The evidence supports the statement in a qualified form: political authority fragmented substantially, while economic and cultural life reorganised around new regional centres rather than collapsing uniformly alongside it.

Why this earns marks: It treats the statement's two halves separately with distinct named evidence for each, and qualifies the continuity claim rather than overstating it into "no decline occurred."



Visual 33: answer spine -- 20-mark: full historiography-weighted verdict

Visual 33: answer spine -- 20-mark: full historiography-weighted verdict. Schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Demand decoding: This "examine" demand tests a two-part statement; it requires distinct, separately evidenced treatment of the fragmentation half and the continuity half, not one blended paragraph.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: This answer's three evidence paragraphs - political, economic, cultural - are this topic's own thesis material and may be used directly, each addressing one half of the statement.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 250 words: one thesis sentence, one fragmentation-evidence paragraph, one economic-continuity paragraph, one cultural-continuity paragraph, and a closing qualified verdict.

How to improve this answer: Name one additional regional court beyond Lucknow and Hyderabad to broaden the cultural-continuity evidence base.

Mains 6 - 20 marks | 250 words

Question: "The rise of Jats, Sikhs and Marathas in the eighteenth century represented not a collapse of order but a redistribution of political power." Discuss.

Directive alignment: Discuss a reframing claim, testing it against each of the three named cases individually.

Introduction: Read through this topic's zamindar-resistance and centre-region-spectrum framework, the rise of the Jats, Sikhs and Marathas is better described as a redistribution of political power along existing social fault lines than a simple collapse into disorder.

The Jat case: Consolidated under leaders including Churaman, Badan Singh and Suraj Mal around Agra-Mathura, the Jat state grew from an agrarian, peasant-rooted zamindari base resisting extraction, hardening into Bharatpur's organised regional power - redistribution from imperial to local-agrarian control, not anarchy.

The Sikh case: Passing through Banda Bahadur's rebellion (1708-1716) and later re-emerging as the mid-century Sikh misls, this shows redistribution to a religious-military confederacy in Punjab, distinct in form from the Jat case but following the same pattern of local resistance consolidating into durable regional power.

The Maratha case: Already an established regional state by 1707, the Marathas layered chauth and sardeshmukhi claims over the continuing Mughal revenue base (formalised in the 1719 Sayyid settlement) and projected power as far as Bengal and the Punjab, redistributing fiscal sovereignty over a wide geography while the agrarian-fiscal base persisted.

Qualification: These three formations differed sharply in social base and mechanism and should not be collapsed into one undifferentiated "resistance" category; each requires its own named evidence.

Verdict: In all three cases, the evidence supports "redistribution" over "collapse": political authority moved to new, locally rooted centres of power over a continuing agrarian-fiscal base, rather than dissolving into an absence of order.

Why this earns marks: It tests the reframing claim against three distinct, individually evidenced cases rather than asserting it in general terms, and explicitly guards against collapsing distinct formations into one category.

Demand decoding: This "discuss" demand requires the redistribution-versus-collapse reframing to be tested against each of the three named cases individually, not asserted as one general claim.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: This answer's three case-paragraphs - Jat, Sikh, Maratha - are this topic's own comparative material and may be used directly, each with its own named leaders and dates.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 250 words: one thesis sentence, three case paragraphs (Jat, Sikh, Maratha) each with named leaders and dates, and a closing verdict distinguishing redistribution from collapse.

How to improve this answer: Name one additional Maratha fiscal detail, such as the 1719 chauth and sardeshmukhi settlement, directly inside the Maratha case paragraph to strengthen its evidentiary anchor.

Mains 7 - 20 marks | 250 words

Question: "The decline of the Mughal empire made British colonial rule in India inevitable." Critically examine this proposition.

Directive alignment: Critically examine a strong inevitability claim, weighing supporting and opposing evidence before a qualified verdict.

Introduction: This proposition claims a direct, necessary causal line from Mughal fragmentation to British paramountcy; this topic's own evidence supports a more qualified position.

Evidence that could support the proposition: Mughal fragmentation - the jagirdari crisis, noble factionalism, and the rise of autonomous successor states and regional powers - did create a genuinely weakened, multi-polar political landscape in which no single Indian power held unchallenged paramountcy, an environment an ambitious external actor could exploit.

Evidence against inevitability: This same fragmented landscape contained several substantial regional powers - Bengal's Nawabi, Awadh, Hyderabad, the Maratha confederacy, and Jat and Sikh formations - any of which represented a plausible alternative regional trajectory; nothing in this topic's 1707-1761 evidence uniquely predicts British success over, say, a Maratha-led or Bengal-centred outcome. British paramountcy additionally required its own contingent institutional innovations - a disciplined sepoy army, a subsidiary-alliance method, and a Bengal revenue-extraction model built after 1757-1765 - which belong to Modern History and are not derivable from Mughal fragmentation alone.

Qualification: Denying any connection at all would also be wrong; fragmentation is a necessary permissive condition without which the Company's later gains would have been far harder, even though it is not a sufficient cause by itself.

Verdict: Mughal decline created the open, contested conditions under which British paramountcy became possible, but the proposition's claim of inevitability overreaches; the specific outcome required Modern History's own contingent sequence of events and institutions, not a predetermined path.

Why this earns marks: It weighs both directions of the argument with specific named evidence, correctly separates "permissive condition" from "sufficient cause," and reaches a critical, non-teleological verdict rather than simply agreeing or disagreeing.

Demand decoding: This "critically examine" demand requires both supporting and opposing evidence for the inevitability claim before a qualified verdict, not a one-sided agreement or rejection.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: This answer's for/against paragraphs are this topic's own non-inevitability material; the institutional-innovation clause must stay hedged as this topic's own bounded hand-off to Modern History.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 250 words: one thesis sentence, one supporting-evidence paragraph, one opposing-evidence paragraph naming specific alternative regional powers, and a closing critical

verdict separating permissive condition from sufficient cause.

How to improve this answer: Name one additional regional power's contingent strength beyond Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad to sharpen the "plausible alternative trajectory" claim.